



WE'RE EYEBALL TO EYEBALL, AND I THINK THE OTHER FELLOW JUST BLINKED

THE CUBAN MISSILE CRISIS (1962)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Nuclear arms race

BEFORE

1942–1945 The US sets up the Manhattan Project to develop the first nuclear weapon.

1945 The US drops atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, ending World War II.

1952–1953 Both the US and USSR develop the H-bomb, 1,000 times stronger than the atomic bomb.

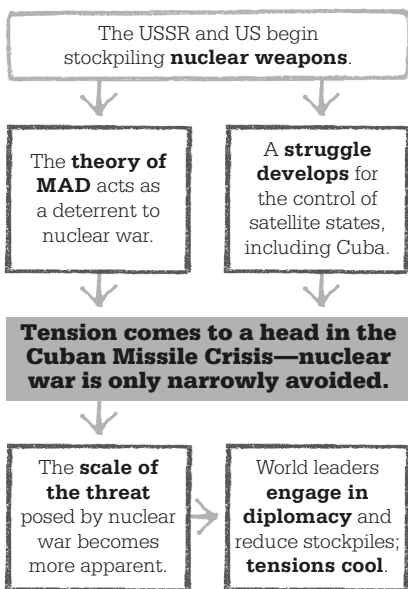
AFTER

1963 The US and Russia agree to a nuclear test-ban treaty, and tensions lessen.

1969–1972 Strategic Arms Limitation Talks (SALT I) yield a superpower agreement on missile deployment.

1991 Strategic Arms Reductions Treaty I (START I) reduces the numbers of US and Soviet long-range missiles.

For 13 days, from October 15 to October 28, 1962, the world teetered on the edge of nuclear destruction. Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev had deployed nuclear weapons in Cuba, and US president John F. Kennedy demanded he remove them. Each threatened nuclear war.



This was no empty threat: from the 1950s, both superpowers had begun stockpiling vast nuclear arsenals. Strategists articulated the mutually assured destruction (MAD) doctrine, which held that if Russia attacked the West, the West would make sure that they retaliate. In short, there would be no winners.

When Kennedy became president in 1961, he inherited a deteriorating relationship with Cuba. The US and Cuba had a history of mutual cooperation, but this had changed with the Cuban Revolution, when, on January 1, 1959, Fidel Castro